Feeding as Reciprocal Regulation, Not a Transfer of Calories

Responsive feeding is a cue-based, bidirectional process inside ordinary caregiving; it is not a weight or IQ program, and it is not the suck–swallow or breastfeeding-cognition claim.

DE: MODERATE-FRAMEWORK; LOW-GROWTH-PROGRAM | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: REGULATION, FEEDING | REPLICATION: VERI

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

After placental transfer ends, feeding is one of the first problems an infant and caregiver solve together. The infant signals hunger, satiety, interest, or refusal. The adult offers, waits, pauses, or persists. Black & Aboud (2011) describe responsive feeding as a four-step reciprocal process: the adult provides structure and an emotional context; the child signals; the adult responds promptly in a contingent, developmentally fitted way; the child meets a predictable consequence. The construct comes from nutrition, psychology, and anthropology. It is a description of an interaction, not a calorie count.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Black & Aboud (2011), Journal of Nutrition: theoretical synthesis for a responsive-feeding supplement, not an RCT of ordinary household differences. Identification is conceptual and review-level. Suck–swallow–breathe coordination (Lau 2015) is a maturational physiology claim. PROBIT/sibling breastfeeding-IQ is a cognition claim. Neither is this card.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

No portable effect size for ordinary cue-based feeding as a developmental intervention. Persistence of growth or cognitive advantage is not established here.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (behavioral feeding framework, not an observational population phenotype association).

Poverty, food availability, illness, and caregiver strain are easily mistaken for “feeding style.” Cross-cultural feeding practices vary; the four-step description should not be read as a single correct script.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean forcing intake, ignoring satiety, or ranking families by feeding method. Does not mean breastfeeding associations with later cognition. Does not mean a missed feed writes a life.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Ordinary noticing of hunger and satiety cues, and skilled feeding support where wanted or needed. Treating a feeding protocol as cognitive enhancement is not justified.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Black & Aboud (2011), Journal of Nutrition (DOI 10.3945/jn.110.129973)